



**SHEKHAWAT WITH VASUNDHARA RAJE,
A FORMER PROTEGE AND NOW HIS
MAIN TARGET**

silent for so long? His detractors see it as a bargain ploy: earlier he wanted a safe seat for his son-in-law Narpal Singh Rajvi, the industries minister in the Raje cabinet, who anticipated a humiliating defeat in his Chittorgarh constituency. The BJP was opposed to giving safe seats to those who failed to keep them earlier. After getting a new constituency for Rajvi, Shekhawat wanted him to be made the leader of the Opposition as well, a demand that had few backers.

The veteran has also demanded a full say in ticket distribution in the Lok Sabha polls, keeping Raje and the state party President Om Mathur out

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of the process. His main concern is to ensure tickets for some of his supporters. Shekhawat's initial target was Advani who he thought would sacrifice Raje for maintaining peace. That didn't happen. Shekhawat got furious. He is nobody's fool. He is aware of his constructive as well as destructive powers and of his image as a man who gave so much to the party. After all, it was Shekhawat who set the stage for the first woman chief minister in a state known for its Rajput machismo. He is a social reformer too. He stood against Sati when many Rajput lead-

ers were backing it. He fought for abolition of the jagirdar system and favoured big landlords. Later many landowning Thakurs went on to become his supporters and admirers. He is the only Rajput leader who has spoken for widow remarriage within the community. He cannot afford to be ignored.

A Shekhawat running amok is bad news for the BJP which seems to have lost its script with barely three months before the Lok Sabha elections. The party pretended that they had things well under control when they announced their prime ministerial candidate way back in December 2007, and then dared the Congress to do the same. To present a picture of unity, they even announced their first list of candidates for the Lok Sabha polls last year. Now, suddenly, things are falling apart. The dust had barely settled on the mysterious disappearance of Rs 2.6 crore from the BJP headquarters that the new challenge in the form of Shekhawat emerged.

The party's central leaders are claiming that the Shekhawat episode will not leave any lasting impact on the BJP's chances in the Lok Sabha polls. They say that he does not have any real clout to be a spoilsport. Party President Rajnath Singh refuses to comment on the controversy, saying that Shekhawat is a senior leader in the party and they all have utmost respect for him. Advani supporters in the party prefer playing down the issue, saying that there is no threat from Shekhawat as he is only a regional leader.

Shekhawat's rebellion shows the power of the antiquated within the party. Just think of it: its prime ministerial candidate is 81 years old. Chaman Lal Gupta, 75, is the leader in Jammu and Kashmir and O.P. Kohli, 76, heads the Delhi unit.

Shekhawat is not the only problem for the BJP. The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)—which forms the backbone of the party cadre and is all the more important in the run-up to the elections—has been pushing the BJP to adopt a more pro-Hindutva stance. The RSS thinks

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